goon, suspended from the emblematic crane of the salt warehouse. The angular initials, nesting in each other like a gigantic tangram puzzle, prefigured the signature niches of the upcoming KNMA Centre in Delhi's Aerocity. This gigantic public arts complex (of 100,000 sq. metres) is scheduled to open its doors in a little over two years' time and will provide a permanent home for the Husain immersive. In the meantime, *M.F. Husain: The Rooted Nomad* show, which coincides with the 2024 Venice Biennale and resonates closely with its theme, 'Foreigners Everywhere', will be delighting art lovers and Venetians till November 24.

If you're wondering what Husain would have made of all this—it's a no-brainer: he would have been extremely pleased. He had his own biennale debut here some 70 years ago, in 1954. For all his barefoot maverick persona, Husain was also very much an insider of the well-heeled, party-hopping world on display at *The Rooted Nomad* opening night. After an eclectic performance by the violin-playing Shankar sisters, whose Hindustani classical glissandos later segued into a rendition of the Farida Khanum number *'Aaj jaane ki zid na karo'* (apparently a Nadar favourite), Gaurav Malvai, a popular DJ from Delhi, ensured that the party continued till 2 am with a mix of western and desi dance music. The 73-year-old Nadar held out, a doughty host, until the festivities ended, stopping short of the after-party, which, rumour has it, continued in an Airbnb palazzo into the wee hours.

Husain himself had a reputation as a very gregarious but somewhat eccentric host, prone to shepherding his friends to a venue and then disappearing. But his own party soundtrack was referenced in the immersive show, which featured Geeta Dutt, Ghulam Ali and, more surprisingly, a couple of tracks from Pink Floyd's 1973 album, *Dark Side of the Moon*. Inevitably, one of these tracks was 'Money', its famous ka-ching sound effects a timely reminder that the revered artist was also notorious for his gimmickry, commercialism and opportunism. "He was admired and criticised," said Roobina Karode, the KNMA's director and chief curator (and the curator of *The Rooted Nomad*), "but that would be true of any prolific artist. He wouldn't hold back. His idiosyncrasies are known." Kiran Nadar was similarly protective: "He wasn't a controversial person," she said,



TOTAL SATURATION KNMA founder and chairperson Kiran Nadar in the installation *M.F. Husain: The Rooted Nomad*

Surround Show

The Rooted Nomad immersive uses motion graphics, 3D animation and a tapestry of sound to craft a digital deep dive into Husain's story

A dizzying and disorienting experience full of surprises, *The Rooted Nomad* immersive in the enormous vaulted hall of the Magazzini del Sale in Venice takes viewers on a 45-minute-long roller coaster ride through the life and career of M.F. Husain. The product of two years of digital and real-world labour by the Italian firm Visioni Srl, a pioneering outfit in immersive shows, this production melds motion graphics, live action, 3D animation effects and a tapestry of sound, including the artist's own voice and contemporary music, to stun its audience into Husain mindfulness. This is likely the first time an Indian artist has received this kind of high-tech treatment, but Visioni are veterans, having produced one of the earliest in this genre, the van Gogh immersive exhibit, billed as 'the most successful exhibition in the world' in terms of Ticketmaster sales (in 2021). Fortunately (if you happen to be in Venice before November), the Husain show is unticketed. It will be screened (if that's the term) in the KNMA's new centre in Delhi's Aerocity. Purists might carp that the whizz-bang tech distracts from the tactile craft of this most athletic artist. But if you want to see the original analogue Husain immersive, you can try the Husain-Doshi Gufa (now the Amdavad ni Gufa) in Ahmedabad.

Photographs by MOHAMMED ROSHAN